

- Despite the *machismo* inherent in the gangster genre, there are several strong and empowered female characters in the show. In the focus episode we are introduced to Polly, a matriarchal figure; Ada, a rebellious daughter; and Grace, who though initially ‘too pretty’ for the pub, is revealed as a cunning undercover agent. Knight has said this reflects the burst in female independence during WWI, where women ‘took over’ running the country.
- These portrayals could raise interesting discussion about the way working class lives and communities, as well as gender roles, are shown in historical dramas.

The effect of historical context on representations

Representations of class/local identity:

- Knight and his producers have said they were deliberately trying to offer a darker and less upper-class view of British history between the world wars.
- This could be seen as **historical revisionism** – a deliberate attempt to excavate alternative versions of a historical period by looking at the lives the lower classes, women, LGBTQ, or migrant people, instead of royalty and wealthy people.
- *Peaky Blinders* doesn’t downplay the squalor of the industrial city, but it does portray it as a place of community, grudging respect and frequent excitement.
- To contrast these two representations of industrial Birmingham, you could consider Tommy’s ride in the opening sequence to Campbell’s journey from the train station (and ensuing sermon).
- Knight has pointed out that in 1919, Birmingham was seen as ‘the workshop of the world’, a hub for the British Empire, manufacturing all the things needed to maintain that empire. The ambitions and plans of the Shelby clan represent this as a place of dirt and poverty, but also remarkable opportunity.

Representations of gender:

- Tommy, like many other gangster characters in the genre is seen as ‘**tough guy with a heart of gold**’. Though emotionally restrained and capable of bursts of incredible violence, he is kind to children and the elderly and wants to support (and defend) his community.
- Though the violence in the show has been criticised, the *machismo* of the many of the characters is rooted by previous trauma. This adds a layer of vulnerability to traditional ‘tough guy’ gangsters.
- As noted above, the female characters in the show are more complex and narratively significant than the usual ‘gangster’s moll’ and sex workers featured in the genre. Polly particularly has more backstory and nuance to her character than a superficial crime family matriarch, including a problematic relationship with motherhood and her extended family.
- Grace is also an interesting female representation. Initially she is a fish-out-of-water, ‘too pretty’ for the area, who can calm a bar with her siren’s song. Later it is revealed she is a ruthless and dedicated undercover agent who has adopted a ‘pretty’ disguise to get closer to Tommy.

Consider theoretical approaches

Identity theory – David Gauntlett

- Gauntlett asserts that audiences actively borrow from media texts to help construct their identity: ‘**a narrative of the self**’. These are not stable, they are **fluid**, depending on the media text and characters being consumed.
- Long form **multi-protagonist** drama offers audiences a range of different characters for audiences to identify with. Even when they are in conflict (e.g. battles between favourite characters in *Game of Thrones*), we still identify with them. This also suggests a fluid nature to identity.
- By showing a brutal yet highly stylised representation of working-class Midlands life, Gauntlett would say *Peaky Blinders* is promoting a diversity of identities. Instead of